

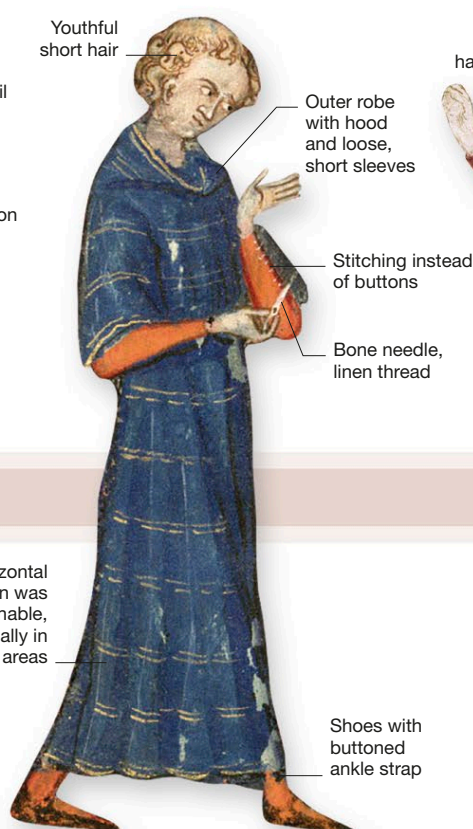
1300–1380

FITTING TO THE BODY

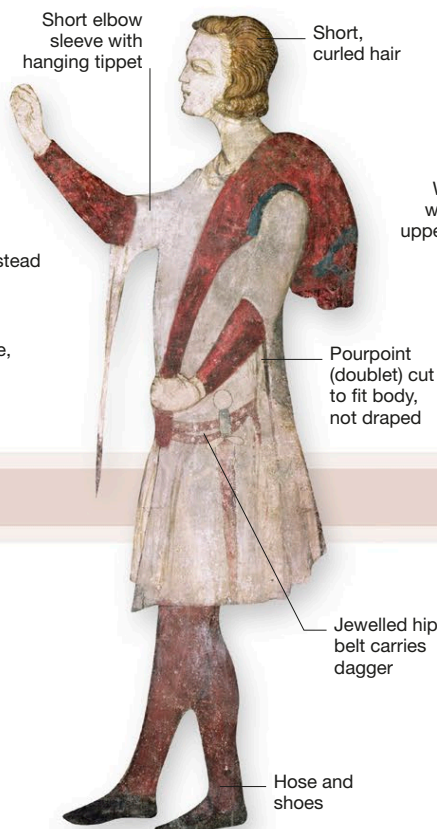
The biggest development of the 14th century was the move from flat, draped garments belted for shape to the cutting of curved pieces with more complex construction to fit the body – the beginning of tailoring. Fastenings, especially buttons, became more important, used on new front openings and along very tight long sleeves. Close fitting revealed men's and women's figures to great effect: sideless surcoats drew attention to slim waists and new waist seams, and low belts emphasized the hips. Chests looked larger – both sexes made use of padding. Colours began to contrast instead of match, and parti-colouring became popular. Many believe that changes in “fashion” began increasing in speed from this time. Clothing had tended to reflect one's place in society. However, a greater variety of fabrics and accessories, such as hoods, belts, veils, gloves, and shoes, made it possible to blur social distinctions.



Reproduction sideless surcoat The surcoat armholes are enlarged to display the sides of the body clad in a clinging *cote-hardie* beneath. The central plastron section could be richly jewelled or embroidered, or have elaborate buttons.



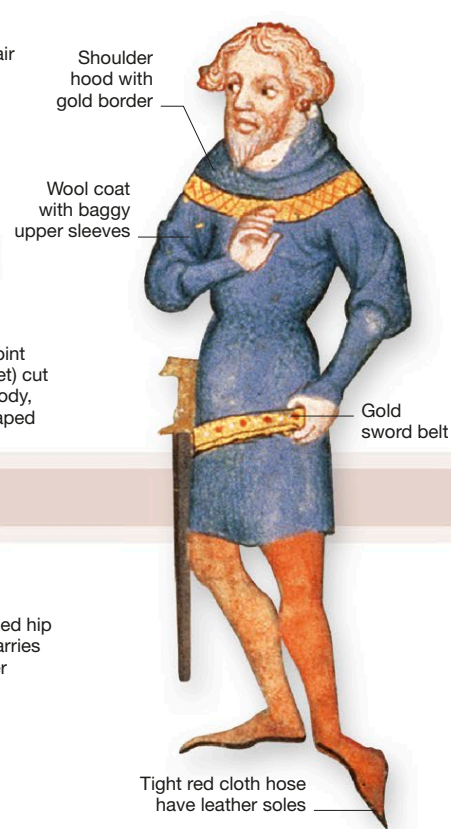
Sewing a sleeve For the fashionable man, getting dressed might involve sewing sleeve and other seams together for a smooth, perfect fit. This man's long robe prefigures the *houppelande*, a wide-sleeved, flared outer garment.



A southern French hunter A hunting companion in 1343 has slung his hood with a long *cornette* (tail) over one shoulder. Separate hoods ended in shoulder capes and offered another site for elegant arrangement.



Side-lacing Lacing was still a feature in Spain in 1320. In other areas, the laces that could help achieve the fashionable tightness are rarely seen in images. This red undertunic draws attention to a narrow waist and swelling hips.



French knight This 1378 image shows the classic 14th-century male shape: hair at ear-length; nipped-in waist; round chest; tight lower sleeves over the hand; slim, fitted hips with no fullness below, set off with a belt; and pointed toes.